The American Civil War

The American Civil War occurred from 1861 to 1865 and is known to be the bloodiest conflict in American history. It occurred between what were known as the Union and the Confederate States. The Unionists included 23 free states and 5 border states, all of which were led by Abraham Lincoln. The Confederate States were all located within southern USA and refused the new policy changes initiated by the national government. There was a significantly different view of political structure, social structure and slavery between the two sides. Abraham Lincoln and the Republicans wished to ban slavery but the Confederate States saw this as an attempt to curtail their rights. They held the view that each state should have its own right to create specific laws concerning its own social structure.

One of the earliest battles recorded begins with General Beauregard from the Confederate States. He took command of around 22,000 soldiers in 1861 at the Manassas Junction and set camp. He was attacked by General McDowell and 30,000 soldiers from the Union. McDowell seemed to have the upper hand at first but was forced to retreat when Thomas Jackson brought reinforcements from the south.

In April of 1862, the Unionists were able to secure an important win at Shiloh. The Confederates won some important battles but were incapable of driving the Unionists away entirely. Fresh troops arrived that same night to aid the Unionists, which resulted in the Confederates having to withdraw. New Orleans fell under the control of the Unionists and then Baton Rouge the following month.

In the same year, General McClellan commenced the Peninsular Campaign and was able to take control of Yorktown in May. At the end of the month, General McClellan finally made it to Richmond. In June, he was attacked by General Robert E. Lee during the Seven Days battles and McClellan had no choice but to withdraw. During late summer, Generals McClellan and Lee faced each other at the Second Manassas. The south won and the northerners were force to retreat. General Lee started marching towards the